

'You are welcome, monsieur,' said Milady, in a voice whose singular sweetness contrasted with the symptoms of ill-humour which D'Arragnan had just remarked; 'you have today acquired eternal rights to my gratitude.'

The Englishman then turned round and described the combat without omitting a single detail. Milady listened with the greatest attention, and yet it was easily to be perceived, whatever effort she made to conceal her impressions, that this recital was not agreeable to her. The blood rose to her head, and her little foot worked with impatience beneath her robe.

Lord de Winter perceived nothing of this. When he had finished, he went to a table upon which was a salver with Spanish wine and glasses. He filled two glasses, and by a sign invited D'Arragnan to drink.

D'Arragnan knew it was considered disobliging by an Englishman to refuse to pledge him. He therefore drew near to the table and took the second glass. He did not, however, lose sight of Milady; and in a mirror he perceived the change that came over her face. Now that she believed herself to be no longer observed, a sentiment resembling ferocity animated her countenance. She bit her handkerchief with her beautiful teeth.

That pretty little *soubrette* whom D'Arragnan had already observed then came in. She spoke some words to Lord de Winter in English, who thereupon requested D'Arragnan's permission to retire, excusing himself on account of the urgency of the business that had called him away, and charging his sister to obtain his pardon.

D'Arragnan exchanged a shake of the hand with Lord de Winter, and then returned to Milady. Her countenance, with surprising mobility, had recovered its gracious expression; but some little red spots on her handkerchief indicated that she had bitten her lips till the blood came. Those lips were magnificent; they might be said to be of coral.

The conversation took a cheerful turn. Milady appeared to have entirely recovered. She told D'Arragnan that Lord de Winter was her brother-in-law, and not her brother. She had married a younger brother of the family, who had left her a widow with one child. This child was the only heir to Lord de Winter, if Lord de Winter did not marry. All this showed D'Arragnan that there was a veil which concealed something; but he could not yet see under this veil.

In addition to this, after a half hour's conversation D'Arragnan was convinced that Milady was his compatriot; she spoke French with an elegance and a purity that left no doubt on that head.

D'Arragnan was profuse in gallant speeches and protestations of devotion. To all the simple things which escaped our Gascon, Milady replied with a smile of kindness. The hour came for him to retire. D'Arragnan took leave of Milady, and left the saloon the happiest of men.

On the staircase he met the pretty *soubrette*, who brushed gently against him as she passed, and then, blushing to the eyes, asked his pardon for having touched him in a voice so sweet that the pardon was granted instantly.

D'Arragnan came again on the morrow, and was still better received than on the evening before. Lord de Winter was not at home; and it was Milady who this time did all the honours of the evening. She appeared to take a great interest in him, asked him whence he came, who were his friends, and whether he had not sometimes thought of attaching himself to the cardinal.

D'Arragnan, who, as we have said, was exceedingly prudent for a young man of twenty, then remembered his suspicions regarding Milady. He launched into a eulogy of his Eminence, and said that he should not have failed to enter into the Guards of the cardinal instead of the king's Guards if he had happened to know M. de Cavois instead of M. de Tréville.

Milady changed the conversation without any appearance of affectation, and asked D'Arragnan in the most careless manner possible if he had ever been in England.

D'Arragnan replied that he had been sent thither by M. de Tréville to treat for a supply of horses, and that he had brought back four as specimens.

Milady in the course of the conversation twice or thrice bit her lips; she had to deal with a Gascon who played close.

At the same hour as on the preceding evening, D'Arragnan retired. In the corridor he again met the pretty Kitty; that was the name of the *soubrette*. She looked at him with an expression of kindness which it was impossible to mistake; but D'Arragnan was so preoccupied by the mistress that he noticed absolutely nothing but her.

D'Arragnan came again on the morrow and the day after that, and each day Milady gave him a more gracious reception.

Every evening, either in the antechamber, the corridor, or on the stairs, he met the pretty *soubrette*. But, as we have said, D'Artagnan paid no attention to this persistence of poor Kitty.

'I loved Madame Bonacieux with my heart, while I only love Milady with my head,' said he. 'In getting introduced to her, my principal object is to ascertain what part she plays at court.'

'The part she plays, *pardieu!* It is not difficult to divine that, after all you have told me. She is some emissary of the cardinal; a woman who will draw you into a snare in which you will leave your head.'

'The devil! my dear Athos, you view things on the dark side, methinks.'

'My dear fellow, I mistrust women. Can it be otherwise? I bought my experience dearly—particularly fair women. Milady is fair, you say?'

'She has the most beautiful light hair imaginable!'

'Ah, my poor D'Artagnan!' said Athos.

'Listen to me! I want to be enlightened on a subject; then, when I shall have learned what I desire to know, I will withdraw.'

'Be enlightened!' said Athos, phlegmatically.

Lord de Winter arrived at the appointed time; but Athos, being warned of his coming, went into the other chamber. He therefore found D'Artagnan alone, and as it was nearly eight o'clock he took the young man with him.

An elegant carriage waited below, and as it was drawn by two excellent horses, they were soon at the Place Royale.

Milady Clarik received D'Artagnan ceremoniously. Her hôtel was remarkably sumptuous, and while the most part of the English had quit, or were about to quit, France on account of the war, Milady had just been laying out much money upon her residence; which proved that the general measure which drove the English from France did not affect her.

'You see,' said Lord de Winter, presenting D'Artagnan to his sister, 'a young gentleman who has held my life in his hands, and who has not abused his advantage, although we have been twice enemies, although it was I who insulted him, and although I am an Englishman. Thank him, then, madame, if you have any affection for me.'

Milady frowned slightly; a scarcely visible cloud passed over her brow, and so peculiar a smile appeared upon her lips that the young man, who saw and observed this triple shade, almost shuddered at it.

The brother did not perceive this; he had turned round to play with Milady's favourite monkey, which had pulled him by the doublet.

Porthos shrugged his shoulders; Aramis by a movement of his lips endorsed Athos.

‘Then,’ said D’Aragnan, ‘let us give the money to the lackeys, as Lord de Winter desired us to do.’

‘Yes,’ said Athos, ‘let us give the money to the lackeys—not to our lackeys, but to the lackeys of the Englishmen.’

Athos took the purse, and threw it into the hand of the coachman. ‘For you and your comrades.’

This greatness of spirit in a man who was quite destitute struck even Porthos; and this French generosity, repeated by Lord de Winter and his friend, was highly applauded, except by MM. Grimaud, Bazin, Mousqueton and Planchet.

Lord de Winter, on quitting D’Aragnan, gave him his sister’s address. She lived in the Place Royale—then the fashionable quarter—at Number 6, and he undertook to call and take D’Aragnan with him in order to introduce him. D’Aragnan appointed eight o’clock at Athos’s residence.

This introduction to Milady Clarik occupied the head of our Gascon greatly. He remembered in what a strange manner this woman had hitherto been mixed up in his destiny. According to his conviction, she was some creature of the cardinal, and yet he felt himself invincibly drawn toward her by one of those sentiments for which we cannot account. His only fear was that Milady would recognize in him the man of Meung and of Dover. Then she knew that he was one of the friends of M. de Tréville, and consequently, that he belonged body and soul to the king; which would make him lose a part of his advantage, since when known to Milady as he knew her, he played only an equal game with her. As to the commencement of an intrigue between her and M. de Wardes, our presumptuous hero gave but little heed to that, although the marquís was young, handsome, rich, and high in the cardinal’s favour. It is not for nothing we are but twenty years old, above all if we were born at Tarbes.

D’Aragnan began by making his most splendid toilet, then returned to Athos’s, and according to custom, related everything to him. Athos listened to his projects, then shook his head, and recommended prudence to him with a shade of bitterness.

‘What!’ said he, ‘you have just lost one woman, whom you call good, charming, perfect; and here you are, running headlong after another.’

D’Aragnan felt the truth of this reproach.

Chapter XXXII

A Procurator’s Dinner



HOWEVER brilliant had been the part played by Porthos in the duel, it had not made him forget the dinner of the procurator’s wife.

On the morrow he received the last touches of Mousqueton’s brush for an hour, and took his way toward the Rue aux Ours with the steps of a man who was doubly in favour with fortune.

His heart beat, but not like D’Aragnan’s with a young and impatient love. No; a more material interest stirred his blood. He was about at last to pass that mysterious threshold, to climb those unknown stairs by which, one by one, the old crowns of M. Coquenard had ascended. He was about to see in reality a certain coffer of which he had twenty times beheld the image in his dreams—a coffer long and deep, locked, bolted, fastened in the wall; a coffer of which he had so often heard, and which the hands—a little wrinkled, it is true, but still not without elegance—of the procurator’s wife were about to open to his admiring looks.

And then he—a wanderer on the earth, a man without fortune, a man without family, a soldier accustomed to inns, cabarets, taverns, and restaurants, a lover of wine forced to depend upon chance treats—was about to partake of family meals, to enjoy the pleasures of a comfortable establishment, and to give himself up to those little attentions which ‘the harder one is, the more they please,’ as old soldiers say.

To come in the capacity of a cousin, and seat himself every day at a good table; to smooth the yellow, wrinkled brow of the old procurator; to pluck the clerks a little by teaching them *bazette*, *passé-dix*, and *lansquenet*, in their utmost nicety, and winning from them, by way of fee for the lesson he would

give them in an hour, their savings of a month—all this was enormously delightful to Porthos.

The Musketeer could not forget the evil reports which then prevailed, and which indeed have survived them, of the procurators of the period—meanness, stinginess, fasts; but as, after all, excepting some few acts of economy which Porthos had always found very unseasonable, the procurator's wife had been tolerably liberal—that is, be it understood, for a procurator's wife—he hoped to see a household of a highly comfortable kind.

And yet, at the very door the Musketeer began to entertain some doubts. The approach was not such as to prepossess people—an ill-smelling, dark passage, a staircase half-lighted by bars through which stole a glimmer from a neighbouring yard; on the first floor a low door studded with enormous nails, like the principal gate of the Grand Châtelet.

Porthos knocked with his hand. A tall, pale clerk, his face shaded by a forest of virgin hair, opened the door, and bowed with the air of a man forced at once to respect in another lofty stature, which indicated strength, the military dress, which indicated rank, and a ruddy countenance, which indicated familiarity with good living.

A shorter clerk came behind the first, a taller clerk behind the second, a stripling of a dozen years rising behind the third. In all, three clerks and a half, which, for the time, argued a very extensive clientele.

Although the Musketeer was not expected before one o'clock, the procurator's wife had been on the watch ever since midday, reckoning that the heart, or perhaps the stomach, of her lover would bring him before his time.

Mme. Coquenard therefore entered the office from the house at the same moment her guest entered from the stairs, and the appearance of the worthy lady relieved him from an awkward embarrassment. The clerks surveyed him with great curiosity, and he, not knowing well what to say to this ascending and descending scale, remained tongue-tied.

'It is my cousin!' cried the procurator's wife. 'Come in, come in, Monsieur Porthos!'

The name of Porthos produced its effect upon the clerks, who began to laugh; but Porthos turned sharply round, and every countenance quickly recovered its gravity.

sword flying. The baron, finding himself disarmed, took two or three steps back, but in this movement his foot slipped and he fell backward.

D'Arragnan was over him at a bound, and said to the Englishman, pointing his sword to his throat, 'I could kill you, my Lord, you are completely in my hands; but I spare your life for the sake of your sister.'

D'Arragnan was at the height of joy; he had realized the plan he had imagined beforehand, whose picturing had produced the smiles we noted upon his face.

The Englishman, delighted at having to do with a gentleman of such a kind disposition, pressed D'Arragnan in his arms, and paid a thousand compliments to the three Musketeers, and as Porthos's adversary was already installed in the carriage, and as Aramis's had taken to his heels, they had nothing to think about but the dead.

As Porthos and Aramis were undressing him, in the hope of finding his wound not mortal, a large purse dropped from his clothes. D'Arragnan picked it up and offered it to Lord de Winter.

'What the devil would you have me do with that?' said the Englishman.

'You can restore it to his family,' said D'Arragnan.

'His family will care much about such a trifle as that! His family will inherit fifteen thousand louis a year from him. Keep the purse for your lackeys.'

D'Arragnan put the purse into his pocket.

'And now, my young friend, for you will permit me, I hope, to give you that name,' said Lord de Winter, 'on this very evening, if agreeable to you, I will present you to my sister, Milady Clarik, for I am desirous that she should take you into her good graces; and as she is not in bad odour at court, she may perhaps on some future day speak a word that will not prove useless to you.'

D'Arragnan blushed with pleasure, and bowed a sign of assent.

At this time Athos came up to D'Arragnan.

'What do you mean to do with that purse?' whispered he.

'Why, I meant to pass it over to you, my dear Athos.'

'Me! why to me?'

'Why, you killed him! They are the spoils of victory.'

'I, the heir of an enemy?' said Athos, 'for whom, then, do you take me?'

'It is the custom in war,' said D'Arragnan, 'why should it not be the custom in a duel?'

'Even on the field of battle, I have never done that.'

'Does that satisfy you?' said Athos to his adversary. 'Do you find me of sufficient rank to do me the honour of crossing swords with me?'

'Yes, monsieur,' said the Englishman, bowing.

'Well! now shall I tell you something?' added Athos, coolly.

'What?' replied the Englishman.

'Why, that is that you would have acted much more wisely if you had not required me to make myself known.'

'Why so?'

'Because I am believed to be dead, and have reasons for wishing nobody to know I am living; so that I shall be obliged to kill you to prevent my secret from roaming over the fields.'

The Englishman looked at Athos, believing that he jested, but Athos did not jest the least in the world.

'Gentlemen,' said Athos, addressing at the same time his companions and their adversaries, 'are we ready?'

'Yes!' answered the Englishmen and the Frenchmen, as with one voice.

'On guard, then!' cried Athos.

Immediately eight swords glittered in the rays of the setting sun, and the combat began with an animosity very natural between men twice enemies.

Athos fenced with as much calmness and method as if he had been practising in a fencing school.

Porthos, abated, no doubt, of his too-great confidence by his adventure of Chantilly, played with skill and prudence. Aramis, who had the third canto of his poem to finish, behaved like a man in haste.

Athos killed his adversary first. He hit him but once, but as he had foretold, that hit was a mortal one; the sword pierced his heart.

Second, Porthos stretched his upon the grass with a wound through his thigh. As the Englishman, without making any further resistance, then surrendered his sword, Porthos took him up in his arms and bore him to his carriage.

Aramis pushed his so vigorously that after going back fifty paces, the man ended by fairly taking to his heels, and disappeared amid the hooting of the lackeys.

As to D'Artagnan, he fought purely and simply on the defensive; and when he saw his adversary pretty well fatigued, with a vigorous side thrust sent his

They reached the office of the procurator after having passed through the antechamber in which the clerks were, and the study in which they ought to have been. This last apartment was a sort of dark room, littered with papers. On quitting the study they left the kitchen on the right, and entered the reception room.

All these rooms, which communicated with one another, did not inspire Porthos favourably. Words might be heard at a distance through all these open doors. Then, while passing, he had cast a rapid, investigating glance into the kitchen; and he was obliged to confess to himself, to the shame of the procurator's wife and his own regret, that he did not see that fire, that animation, that bustle, which when a good repast is on foot prevails generally in that sanctuary of good living.

The procurator had without doubt been warned of his visit, as he expressed no surprise at the sight of Porthos, who advanced toward him with a sufficiently easy air, and saluted him courteously.

'We are cousins, it appears, Monsieur Porthos?' said the procurator, rising, yet supporting his weight upon the arms of his cane chair.

The old man, wrapped in a large black doublet, in which the whole of his slender body was concealed, was brisk and dry. His little gray eyes shone like cabuncles, and appeared, with his grinning mouth, to be the only part of his face in which life survived. Unfortunately the legs began to refuse their service to this bony machine. During the last five or six months that this weakness had been felt, the worthy procurator had nearly become the slave of his wife.

The cousin was received with resignation, that was all. M. Coquenard, firm upon his legs, would have declined all relationship with M. Porthos.

'Yes, monsieur, we are cousins,' said Porthos, without being disconcerted, as he had never reckoned upon being received enthusiastically by the husband. 'By the female side, I believe?' said the procurator, maliciously.

Porthos did not feel the ridicule of this, and took it for a piece of simplicity, at which he laughed in his large moustache. Mme. Coquenard, who knew that a simple-minded procurator was a very rare variety in the species, smiled a little, and coloured a great deal.

M. Coquenard had, since the arrival of Porthos, frequently cast his eyes with great uneasiness upon a large chest placed in front of his oak desk. Porthos comprehended that this chest, although it did not correspond in shape with

that which he had seen in his dreams, must be the blessed coffer, and he congratulated himself that the reality was several feet higher than the dream.

M. Coquenard did not carry his genealogical investigations any further; but withdrawing his anxious look from the chest and fixing it upon Porthos, he contented himself with saying, 'Monsieur our cousin will do us the favour of dining with us once before his departure for the campaign, will he not, Madame Coquenard?'

This time Porthos received the blow right in his stomach, and felt it. It appeared likewise that Mme. Coquenard was not less affected by it on her part, for she added, 'My cousin will not return if he finds that we do not treat him kindly; but otherwise he has so little time to pass in Paris, and consequently to spare to us, that we must entreat him to give us every instant he can call his own previous to his departure.'

'Oh, my legs, my poor legs! where are you?' murmured Coquenard, and he tried to smile.

This succour, which came to Porthos at the moment in which he was attacked in his gastronomic hopes, inspired much gratitude in the Musketeer toward the procurator's wife.

The hour of dinner soon arrived. They passed into the eating room—a large dark room situated opposite the kitchen.

The clerks, who, as it appeared, had smelled unusual perfumes in the house, were of military punctuality, and held their stools in hand quite ready to sit down. Their jaws moved preliminarily with fearful threatnings.

'Indeed!' thought Porthos, casting a glance at the three hungry clerks—for the errand boy, as might be expected, was not admitted to the honours of the magisterial table, 'in my cousin's place, I would not keep such gourmands! They look like shipwrecked sailors who have not eaten for six weeks.'

M. Coquenard entered, pushed along upon his armchair with casters by Mme. Coquenard, whom Porthos assisted in rolling her husband up to the table. He had scarcely entered when he began to agitate his nose and his jaws after the example of his clerks.

'Oh, oh!' said he; 'here is a soup which is rather inviting.'

'What the devil can they smell so extraordinary in this soup?' said Porthos, at the sight of a pale liquid, abundant but entirely free from meat, on the surface of which a few crusts swam about as rare as the islands of an archipelago.

Chapter XXXI

English and French



HE hour having come, they went with their four lackeys to a spot behind the Luxembourg given up to the feeding of goats. Athos threw a piece of money to the goateeper to withdraw. The lackeys were ordered to act as sentinels.

A silent party soon drew near to the same enclosure, entered, and joined the Musketeers. Then, according to foreign custom, the presentations took place.

The Englishmen were all men of rank; consequently the odd names of their adversaries were for them not only a matter of surprise, but of annoyance.

'But after all,' said Lord de Winter, when the three friends had been named, 'we do not know who you are. We cannot fight with such names; they are names of shepherds.'

'Therefore your lordship may suppose they are only assumed names,' said Athos.

'Which only gives us a greater desire to know the real ones,' replied the Englishman.

'You played very willingly with us without knowing our names,' said Athos, 'by the same token that you won our horses.'

'That is true, but we then only risked our pistols; this time we risk our blood. One plays with anybody; but one fights only with equals.'

'And that is but just,' said Athos, and he took aside the one of the four Englishmen with whom he was to fight, and communicated his name in a low voice.

Porthos and Aramis did the same.

Mme. Coquenard smiled, and upon a sign from her everyone eagerly took his seat.

M. Coquenard was served first, then Porthos. Afterward Mme. Coquenard filled her own plate, and distributed the crusts without soup to the impatient clerks. At this moment the door of the dining room unclosed with a creak, and Porthos perceived through the half-open flap the little clerk who, not being allowed to take part in the feast, ate his dry bread in the passage with the double odour of the dining room and kitchen.

After the soup the maid brought a boiled fowl—a piece of magnificence which caused the eyes of the diners to dilate in such a manner that they seemed ready to burst.

‘One may see that you love your family, Madame Coquenard,’ said the procurator, with a smile that was almost tragic. ‘You are certainly treating your cousin very handsomely!’

The poor fowl was thin, and covered with one of those thick, bristly skins through which the teeth cannot penetrate with all their efforts. The fowl must have been sought for a long time on the perch, to which it had retired to die of old age.

‘The devil!’ thought Porthos, ‘this is poor work. I respect old age, but I don’t much like it boiled or roasted.’

And he looked round to see if anybody partook of his opinion; but on the contrary, he saw nothing but eager eyes which were devouring, in anticipation, that sublime fowl which was the object of his contempt.

Mme. Coquenard drew the dish toward her, skilfully detached the two great black feet, which she placed upon her husband’s plate, cut off the neck, which with the head she put on one side for herself, raised the wing for Porthos, and then returned the bird otherwise intact to the servant who had brought it in, who disappeared with it before the Musketeer had time to examine the variations which disappointment produces upon faces, according to the characters and temperaments of those who experience it.

In the place of the fowl a dish of haricot beans made its appearance—an enormous dish in which some bones of mutton that at first sight one might have believed to have some meat on them pretended to show themselves.

But the clerks were not the dupes of this deceit, and their lugubrious looks settled down into resigned countenances.

Mme. Coquenard distributed this dish to the young men with the moderation of a good housewife.

The time for wine came. M. Coquenard poured from a very small stone bottle the third of a glass for each of the young men, served himself in about the same proportion, and passed the bottle to Porthos and Mme. Coquenard.

The young men filled up their third of a glass with water; then, when they had drunk half the glass, they filled it up again, and continued to do so. This brought them, by the end of the repast, to swallowing a drink which from the colour of the ruby had passed to that of a pale topaz.

Porthos ate his wing of the fowl timidly, and shuddered when he felt the knee of the procurator's wife under the table, as it came in search of his. He also drank half a glass of this sparingly served wine, and found it to be nothing but that horrible Montreuil—the terror of all expert palates.

M. Coquenard saw him swallowing this wine undiluted, and sighed deeply.

'Will you eat any of these beans, Cousin Porthos?' said Mme. Coquenard, in that tone which says, 'Take my advice, don't touch them.'

'Devil take me if I taste one of them!' murmured Porthos to himself, and then said aloud, 'Thank you, my cousin, I am no longer hungry.'

There was silence. Porthos could hardly keep his countenance.

The procurator repeated several times, 'Ah, Madame Coquenard! Accept my compliments; your dinner has been a real feast. Lord, how I have eaten!'

M. Coquenard had eaten his soup, the black feet of the fowl, and the only mutton bone on which there was the least appearance of meat.

Porthos fancied they were mystifying him, and began to curl his moustache and knit his eyebrows; but the knee of Mme. Coquenard gently advised him to be patient.

This silence and this interruption in serving, which were unintelligible to Porthos, had, on the contrary, a terrible meaning for the clerks. Upon a look from the procurator, accompanied by a smile from Mme. Coquenard, they arose slowly from the table, folded their napkins more slowly still, bowed, and retired.

'Go, young men! go and promote digestion by working,' said the procurator, gravely.

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The clerks gone, Mme. Coquenard rose and took from a buffet a piece of cheese, some preserved quinces, and a cake which she had herself made of almonds and honey.

M. Coquenard knit his eyebrows because there were too many good things. Porthos bit his lips because he saw not the wherewithal to dine. He looked to see if the dish of beans was still there; the dish of beans had disappeared.

'A positive feast!' cried M. Coquenard, turning about in his chair, 'a real feast, *epulæ epulorum*. Lucullus dines with Lucullus.'

Porthos looked at the bottle, which was near him, and hoped that with wine, bread, and cheese, he might make a dinner; but wine was wanting, the bottle was empty. M. and Mme. Coquenard did not seem to observe it.

'This is fine!' said Porthos to himself; 'I am prettily caught!'

He passed his tongue over a spoonful of preserves, and struck his teeth into the sticky pastry of Mme. Coquenard.

'Now,' said he, 'the sacrifice is consummated! Ah! if I had not the hope of peeping with Madame Coquenard into her husband's chest!'

M. Coquenard, after the luxuries of such a repast, which he called an excess, felt the want of a siesta. Porthos began to hope that the thing would take place at the present sitting, and in that same locality; but the procurator would listen to nothing, he would be taken to his room, and was not satisfied till he was close to his chest, upon the edge of which, for still greater precaution, he placed his feet.

The procurator's wife took Porthos into an adjoining room, and they began to lay the basis of a reconciliation.

'You can come and dine three times a week,' said Mme. Coquenard.

'Thanks, madame!' said Porthos, 'but I don't like to abuse your kindness; besides, I must think of my outfit!'

'That's true,' said the procurator's wife, groaning, 'that unfortunate outfit!'

'Alas, yes,' said Porthos, 'it is so.'

'But of what, then, does the equipment of your company consist, Monsieur Porthos?'

'Oh, of many things!' said Porthos. 'The Musketeers are, as you know, picked soldiers, and they require many things useless to the Guardsmen or the Swiss.'

'But yet, detail them to me.'

‘Why, they may amount to—’, said Porthos, who preferred discussing the total to taking them one by one.

The procurator’s wife waited tremblingly.

‘To how much?’ said she. ‘I hope it does not exceed—’ She stopped; speech failed her.

‘Oh, no,’ said Porthos, ‘it does not exceed two thousand five hundred livres! I even think that with economy I could manage it with two thousand livres.’

‘Good God!’ cried she, ‘two thousand livres! Why, that is a fortune!’

Porthos made a most significant grimace; Mme. Coquenard understood it.

‘I wished to know the detail,’ said she, ‘because, having many relatives in business, I was almost sure of obtaining things at a hundred per cent less than you would pay yourself.’

‘Ah, ah!’ said Porthos, ‘that is what you meant to say!’

Yes, dear Monsieur Porthos. Thus, for instance, don’t you in the first place want a horse?’

Yes, a horse.’

‘Well, then! I can just suit you.’

‘Ah!’ said Porthos, brightening, ‘that’s well as regards my horse; but I must have the appointments complete, as they include objects which a Musketeer alone can purchase, and which will not amount, besides, to more than three hundred livres.’

‘Three hundred livres? Then put down three hundred livres,’ said the procurator’s wife, with a sigh.

Porthos smiled. It may be remembered that he had the saddle which came from Buckingham. These three hundred livres he reckoned upon putting snugly into his pocket.

‘Then,’ continued he, ‘there is a horse for my lackey, and my valise. As to my arms, it is useless to trouble you about them; I have them.’

‘A horse for your lackey?’ resumed the procurator’s wife, hesitatingly; ‘but that is doing things in lordly style, my friend.’

‘Ah, madame!’ said Porthos, haughtily; ‘do you take me for a beggar?’

‘No; I only thought that a pretty mule makes sometimes as good an appearance as a horse, and it seemed to me that by getting a pretty mule for Mousqueton—’

The Three Musketeers

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Alexandre Dumas